

Week 1: The Problem Worth Solving

Target Creativity Skill: Design Thinking & User Empathy

Story Context

It's the first day of the university startup incubator program. Georgi, Maria, Ivan, and Elena have formed a team but haven't yet decided what to build. Maria shares her frustration: "Last semester, I nearly failed Algorithms because I couldn't find anyone to study with—everyone was struggling alone." The team realizes they might be onto something. But before jumping to solutions, they need to truly understand the problem. Today, they'll conduct empathy interviews with their fellow students.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, students will be able to:

- Conduct a structured empathy interview using open-ended questions
- Synthesize interview findings into a user persona
- Use professional English to document user needs and pain points
- Explain the 'Empathize' phase of Design Thinking

Activity Breakdown (45 minutes)

0:00-5:00 — Story Setup & Skill Introduction

Teacher presents the story context and introduces Design Thinking's Empathize phase. Students learn why understanding users comes before building solutions.

5:00-10:00 — Interview Protocol Training

Teacher demonstrates empathy interview techniques. Students receive a template with open-ended question starters.

- Model question: "Tell me about a time when studying was frustrating..."
- Avoid leading questions or suggesting solutions
- Practice active listening cues

10:00-25:00 — Pair Empathy Interviews

Students pair up. Each student interviews their partner (7 min each) about their study challenges, playing the role of StudyBuddy's researchers.

- Interviewer takes notes using the template
- Focus on feelings, workarounds, and unmet needs
- Ask follow-up "why" questions

25:00-40:00 — Persona Creation

In groups of 4, students synthesize their findings into one User Persona poster (digital or paper) representing a typical struggling student.

- Include: Name, Background, Goals, Frustrations, Quote
- Use evidence from interviews, not assumptions

40:00-45:00 — Gallery Walk & Reflection

Groups briefly present their personas (1 min each). Class reflects: What surprised you about what users actually need?

English Deliverable

Output: User Persona Document

A one-page user persona (digital template in Google Docs or Canva) including demographics, goals, frustrations, a representative quote, and 3 key insights from interviews.

Contribution to Final Pitch: Becomes the 'Target User' slide in the final pitch deck.

Key Technical Vocabulary

Term	Definition / Usage
Empathy interview	A user research technique using open-ended questions to understand experiences and emotions
User persona	A fictional representation of a target user based on research data
Pain point	A specific problem or frustration that users experience
Open-ended question	A question that cannot be answered with 'yes' or 'no' and encourages detailed responses
Stakeholder	Anyone who has an interest in or is affected by a product or project

★ Self-Evaluation Rubric

Stars	Creativity Skill Indicators	English Communication Indicators
★★★★★	Asked 5+ follow-up questions; uncovered non-obvious insights; persona based entirely on evidence	Used professional interview language fluently; persona document is clear and error-free
★★★★	Asked 3-4 follow-up questions; found meaningful patterns; persona mostly evidence-based	Interview conducted smoothly; minor language errors in document
★★★	Used provided questions; identified basic pain points; some assumptions in persona	Completed interview with some hesitation; document communicates main ideas
★★	Limited follow-up; surface-level findings; persona contains assumptions	Struggled with interview flow; document has notable errors
★	Did not complete interview or persona lacks research basis	Unable to conduct interview in English; document incomplete

Extension Resources (Fast-Lane Students)

- **Video (5 min):** "Empathy Maps Explained" by NNGroup — www.youtube.com/watch?v=QwF9a56WFWA
- **Article:** IDEO's Human-Centered Design Field Guide (free PDF download)
- **Challenge:** Interview a family member about a daily frustration and create a mini-persona